

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – BLOW, BLOW, THOU WINTER WIND

by
William Shakespeare

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About the Poem

"Blow, Blow, Thou Winter Wind" is a song from Act II, Scene 7 of William Shakespeare's pastoral comedy *As You Like It* (c. 1599), sung by the character Amiens in the Forest of Arden. Made up of two ten-line stanzas, each closed by a cheerful refrain, the song contrasts the harshness of winter weather with the far greater cruelty of human ingratitude and false friendship.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*Blow, blow, thou winter wind,
Thou art not so unkind
As man's ingratitude;
Thy tooth is not so keen,
Although thou art not seen,
Although thy breath be rude.
Heigh-ho! sing, heigh-ho! unto the green holly:
Most friendship is feigning, most loving mere folly:
Then, heigh-ho, the holly!
This life is most jolly.*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker addresses the cold winter wind directly, telling it that even its bitter chill is not as unkind as human ingratitude. Its bite is not as sharp as betrayal, even though the wind cannot be seen and its gusts can feel harsh. The cheerful refrain that follows sings to the evergreen holly, observing that most friendship is false and most love is mere foolishness, yet still insisting – almost defiantly – that life is a jolly thing.

Stanza 2:

*Freeze, freeze, thou bitter sky,
That dost not bite so nigh
As benefits forgot:
Though thou the waters warp,
Thy sting is not so sharp
As friend remember'd not.
Heigh-ho! sing, heigh-ho! unto the green holly:
Most friendship is feigning, most loving mere folly:
Then, heigh-ho, the holly!
This life is most jolly.*

Paraphrasing:

The speaker now addresses the freezing winter sky, saying that even its power to freeze water solid does not sting as painfully as being forgotten by a friend or having one's kindnesses go unappreciated. The same cheerful refrain returns, repeating that friendship is often false and love foolish, while still urging that life be met with good cheer.

Rhyming Scheme

Each ten-line stanza opens with a compact rhyming pattern of roughly AABCCB (for example, *wind* / *unkind*, then *keen* / *seen* framing *ingratitude* / *rude*), followed by a jaunty rhymed refrain on “holy / folly / jolly.” The mixture of tight near-couplets and a bouncy repeated refrain gives the song a light, musical, folk-song quality, well suited to being performed and sung aloud within the play.

Theme

The song contrasts the harshness of nature with the deeper, more painful cruelty of human ingratitude and false friendship. Winter's wind and freezing sky, however unpleasant, are shown to be far gentler than betrayal by a friend or a forgotten kindness. Yet rather than ending in despair, the song insists on meeting life's disappointments with resilience and good humour – a theme that echoes the pastoral, philosophical mood of *As You Like It* as a whole.

Figures of Speech

- **Apostrophe**

The speaker directly addresses the wind and the sky as though they could hear and understand him (“Blow, blow...”, “Freeze, freeze...”).

- **Personification**

The wind and sky are given human qualities – a “tooth,” “breath,” and the capacity for kindness or unkindness.

- **Antithesis / Comparison**

Nature's harshness is repeatedly measured against and judged milder than human cruelty (“Thou art not so unkind / As man's ingratitude”).

- **Refrain**

The “Heigh-ho, sing heigh-ho” refrain is repeated at the end of both stanzas, giving the song a musical, sing-along quality.

- **Paradox / Irony**

The song insists “This life is most jolly” even as it describes betrayal and cold, creating a bittersweet, ironic tone.

- **Symbolism**

The evergreen holly, which stays green through winter, symbolises endurance and cheerfulness in the face of hardship.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What does the speaker say is worse than the winter wind?

Human ingratitude – the speaker says the wind's bite is not as unkind or as sharp as the ingratitude shown by other people.

Q2. What is the freezing sky compared to in the second stanza?

Its bitter cold is compared to, and judged milder than, the pain of forgotten favours and being forgotten by a friend.

Q3. What is the purpose of the “Heigh-ho” refrain?

It gives the song a light, musical, folk-song quality and reinforces its message of staying cheerful despite life's disappointments.

Q4. What does the “green holly” symbolise?

It symbolises endurance and cheerfulness that survive even through the harshness of winter, echoing the song's message of resilience.

Q5. In which play and scene does this song appear, and who sings it?

It appears in Act II, Scene 7 of *As You Like It*, sung by the character Amiens in the Forest of Arden.

Q6. What is the central theme of the song?

That human betrayal and ingratitude hurt more deeply than the harshness of nature, yet life should still be met with cheerfulness and resilience.